

AI Entrepreneurship Hackathon

Sponsored by WorkHuman

Organized by Data Analytics Engineering program at Northeastern University

Overview

The **AI Entrepreneurship Hackathon** is a semester-long, team-based innovation challenge designed to foster collaboration between academia and industry while encouraging the development of practical, market-driven AI solutions. The hackathon targets graduate students with strong technical and analytical backgrounds and emphasizes the application of data analytics and artificial intelligence to real-world problems with commercial and societal impact.

This initiative is open to interdisciplinary teams; however, to ensure strong technical and analytical rigor, **each team must include at least one student currently enrolled in the MS in Data Analytics Engineering program**. Participants will work from concept ideation through proposal development and formal pitching, simulating an entrepreneurial and industry-facing innovation process.

Employee Experience (EX)

Employee Experience (EX) is the designated domain for this hackathon. EX focuses on enhancing how work feels and functions for employees across the entire lifecycle—from onboarding and team integration to development, performance, wellbeing, and retention. Projects in this category should propose AI or data analytics solutions that identify friction points, uncover drivers of engagement and belonging, and recommend concrete, actionable interventions for employees, managers, and HR leaders.

Strong proposals will clearly define a specific EX challenge (e.g., burnout risk, onboarding effectiveness, manager impact, collaboration breakdowns, recognition and appreciation dynamics, or skill growth pathways), explain how relevant signals and data would be used responsibly, and articulate measurable outcomes. These outcomes may include improved engagement, reduced attrition risk, faster time-to-productivity, stronger internal mobility, healthier teams, and overall improvements in organizational effectiveness.

Timeline

The hackathon will run **from January through the end of April**, providing teams with sufficient time to refine their ideas, validate feasibility, and develop compelling proposals.

- February 28: Proposal submission deadline
- March 15: Finalists announced
- April 27: Finalist pitches and winner

Team Composition Requirements

- Teams may consist of students from multiple graduate programs.
- **Each team must include at least one MS in Data Analytics Engineering student.**
- Team size and internal role distribution are left to the discretion of the participants, provided all members actively contribute.

Submission Requirements

All participating teams are required to submit a **detailed written proposal**, which should include, at a minimum:

- Problem statement and motivation
- Proposed AI/data analytics solution
- Technical approach and methodology
- Data sources and feasibility considerations
- Potential impact, use cases, and value proposition
- Implementation plan and high-level timeline

Proposals should demonstrate both technical soundness and entrepreneurial potential.

Selection Process

1. Initial Screening

All submitted proposals will undergo an initial review by the organizing committee and judges. Based on this screening, **five finalist teams** will be selected.

2. Final Pitch Presentation

The selected finalist teams will be invited to deliver a formal pitch to a **six-member judging panel**, composed of:

- **Three industry representatives**
- **Three university representatives**

Each pitch will be evaluated on criteria such as innovation, technical depth, feasibility, impact, and presentation quality.

3. Final Awards

Following the pitch presentations, the judging panel will select:

- **First Place (Winner)** – awarded a **seed fund** sponsored by an industry partner

- **Second Place** – acknowledged with formal recognition
- **Third Place** – acknowledged with formal recognition

Outcomes and Benefits

Participants will gain hands-on experience in:

- Translating AI and data analytics techniques into viable solutions
- Working in interdisciplinary, team-based environments
- Engaging with industry professionals and receiving expert feedback
- Developing entrepreneurial thinking alongside technical excellence

The AI Entrepreneurship Hackathon provides a unique opportunity for students to showcase their skills, explore innovative ideas, and connect with industry partners in a meaningful and impactful way.